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APPS



The best dating apps aren't even dating apps

Amanda Silberling

10:40 AM PDT · July 31, 2025

It's no longer taboo to meet your partner on the internet. The evidence is everywhere: It's on your refrigerator door, where you've hung up the wedding invitations of friends who met on Tinder. It's on your Instagram feed, where a friend shares a sappy post about her one-year anniversary with a woman she met on Hinge.

But when Zeke Rothfels tells people that she met her husband online, she's not talking about swiping left until she finally found the right guy. She's talking about cultivating a relationship across the U.S.-Canada border with a man she met in a Facebook meme group.

"I think we both felt kind of like, is this crazy?" Rothfels told TechCrunch. "Do I acknowledge that this feels like something, or will that ruin it?"

It was crazy, but it was also real — six years later, Rothfels is reminiscing about meeting her husband after she's just put their 2-year-old child to sleep.

Everyone is tired of dating apps. This mass [disillusionment](#) has sent the stocks of dating giants [tumbling](#). The stock prices of Bumble and Match Group — the company behind 45 dating apps, including Tinder, Hinge, and OkCupid — have declined about [90%](#) and [68%](#) over the last five years,

respectively.

Together, these companies have shed [\\$40 billion](#) in market cap since 2021, struggling to capture the attention of Gen Z users.



“Do I acknowledge that this feels like something, or will that ruin it?”

But the internet’s presence in our social lives won’t just disappear. As singles [grow weary](#) of swiping, couples are getting to know each other on traditional social media sites — in the Tumblr “Ask” box, in Reddit DMs, and even on [newer platforms like Bluesky](#).

People may not turn to social media with the intent to find love, but these online spaces naturally forge connections, and sometimes, those connections grow beyond friendship. Here, people are no longer at the mercy of dating apps’ mysterious algorithms and emphasis on physical appearance, nor do they have to face an inexplicable number of [fish photos](#). It makes these unexpected digital “meet-cutes” look more appealing than updating your Tinder profile again.

Swipe fatigue

By 2013, online dating had become the most popular way for heterosexual couples in America to meet, according to the longstanding “[How Couples Meet and Stay Together](#)” study from Stanford. By 2019, about 40% of heterosexual couples had [met online](#), doubling the number of couples who met through friends.

Today, about 30% of all American adults have used dating apps, a figure that [increases](#) to 52% among never-married adults.

With broader adoption, however, people were exposed to the darker sides of dating online. Seven out of 10 online daters said it’s common to [encounter people lying](#) on their profiles, and 66% of women ages 18 to 49 reported being harassed, [according to Pew Research](#). Another 56% said they were sent sexually explicit images they didn’t ask for.

Over time, people began to feel that their experiences on dating apps had become more frustrating than hopeful, and the future of the dating app

giants was called into question.

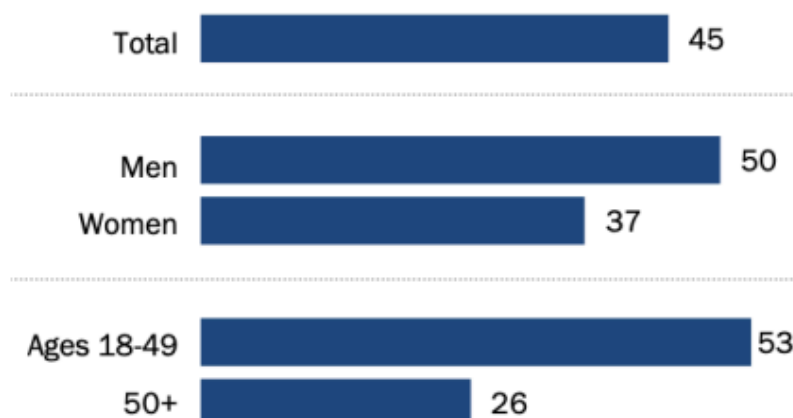
Meanwhile, discouraged dating app users have begun to create online whisper networks where they can discover if others have had negative experiences with their date. The trend started on [“Are we dating the same guy?”-style](#) Facebook Groups, where women would post screenshots of potential dates’ profiles to find out if they were already seeing someone else.

The same concept also powers the newly viral dating advice app [Tea](#), which claims to have 1.6 million users. Its sudden popularity has fueled online debate, where men accuse women of doxxing them, and women point to the necessity of sharing these warnings with others. After all, dating apps largely ignored serious safety concerns, like background checks, according to a 2019 [investigative report by ProPublica and Columbia Journalism Investigations](#), which highlighted the presence of sexual predators on Match-owned dating apps.

Yet the solutions are often as bad as the problems they try to fix. Tea, for example, has seen its security breached twice, with [users’ selfies, private](#)

45% of adults who are ‘single and looking’ have used a dating platform in past year, but this varies by age, gender

Among U.S. adults who are ‘single and looking,’ % who say they have used a dating site or app in the past year



Note: “Single and looking” refers to adults who are not married, living with a partner or in a committed romantic relationship and who are looking for a committed romantic relationship or casual dates. Those who did not give an answer or who gave other responses are not shown.

Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted July 5-17, 2022.

“From Looking for Love to Swiping the Field: Online Dating in the U.S.”

PEW RESEARCH CENTER

IMAGE CREDITS: PEW RESEARCH CENTER



IMAGE CREDITS: SCREENSHOT OF FACEBOOK BY TECHCRUNCH

[messages, and government IDs shared to 4chan](#), a notorious web forum.

It's not surprising, then, that some are giving up online dating altogether.

The new “meeting online”

Rothfels didn't mean to fall in love with a guy from a Facebook meme group who lived in another country. The internet had other plans.

“I always thought he was hot,” Rothfels concedes. “I liked his mustache.”

These [absurdist communities](#), mostly populated with quick-witted, offbeat college students, often had thousands of members. Rothfels and her husband, Owen, had only interacted in passing, but she knew that they had similar senses of humor and political views — otherwise, they wouldn't have both spent so much time in these online spaces.

Owen lived in Minneapolis, and she lived in Toronto, so she never acted on her idle crush. Then one morning in 2019, while she was hungover in bed after a party, she saw that Owen had posted on Instagram about the folk musician Woody Guthrie.

“I replied saying that I'm related to Woody Guthrie, which is true — distantly — and he replied saying, ‘Marry me,’” she said. “That exchange kind of kicked off us talking constantly for the next week ... We basically never stopped messaging each other.”

Though their connection blossomed beyond their shared interest in “elaborate dadaist memes,” the whimsical foundation of their relationship had proven to be the ultimate icebreaker.

“The knowledge that we had both spent a lot of time online making these dumb memes made it less daunting,” Rothfels said.

Elsewhere, demand for alternative ways to meet people is [growing](#), like going to in-person [speed dating](#) events or [mixers](#), turning to [older methods like personal ads](#), [trying apps for offline dating](#), or even joining running clubs, which have become a [weirdly popular](#) avenue for dating.

But like Rothfels, people are finding love in unexpected places — the forums and sites they use to pass idle time online, as opposed to those dedicated to online dating. There, they get to know each other in shared social settings,

where the specter of possible romance doesn't haunt each of their interactions from the first message.

Rudy, a 54-year-old who had never used traditional dating apps, met his wife by chance in an erotic pen pals forum on Reddit, where their identities were obscured by their personas of mythical creatures.

“There’s a great deal of safety thrown into those interactions, at least on Reddit,” Rudy (using a pseudonym) told TechCrunch. “Throwaway Reddit accounts are effectively anonymous.”



I think that Twitter has changed how we communicate and has definitely changed how we relate to other people ... on Twitter, you could be dropping lore every five seconds.

Within their fantastical world, they wrote hundreds of thousands of words to each other, solely because they found it fun. Over the course of a year and a half, their fictional correspondence slowly became more real.

“We explained it as a creative writing forum,” Rudy said. “My family is aware that I met her [online]; they’re just not aware that it was explicitly pornographic, ‘Cthulhu mythos’ stuff.”

Explicit flirtations aside, their creative connection allowed them to get to know each other on a deeper level. Over time, they revealed details about their real lives, and they decided to meet in person. Soon, the woman who became Rudy’s wife moved to the U.S. to be with him.



“My wife’s wit and cleverness ... She makes me laugh more than anybody, and I believe it’s the same for her,” Rudy told TechCrunch. “When we wrote, we wrote lots of poetry together and things like that. That just becomes a connection — we were locked in before we’d ever had any romantic encounter.”

Developing a connection with a friend — even an internet friend — can help speed up the “getting to know you” process that typically comes with online dating, which users have begun to [describe as “admin work”](#) or [a second job](#). In contrast with dating apps, this way of meeting more naturally mimics the feel of meeting through friends.

James Cassar, a writer in their 30s, found a similar sense of common ground with their partner Nicole. The couple originally met on Twitter, where they followed each other because they posted about the same niche rock bands.

When they later matched on Tinder, they already recognized each other from the internet, allowing them to skip the small talk.

“When Nicole looked at my Tinder, she was like, ‘You like Cheem? I don’t know anyone that listens to Cheem,’ and I was like, ‘Then you must know that I’m that person [from Twitter],’” Cassar told TechCrunch. “It’s like a weird CAPTCHA — like, which underground indie band do you like?”

Though they had never spoken, they already knew a lot about each other, since they had been reading each other’s posts for years. And often, people are more open about their thoughts and feelings when they’re posting semi-anonymously to a crowd of internet strangers.

“I think that Twitter has changed how we communicate and has definitely changed how we relate to other people,” Cassar said. “It bypasses a lot of the social contract of like, ‘Oh, I’m gonna meet somebody in person, and we’re gonna get a coffee or something, and then I’m not gonna tell them this embarrassing thing about me until seven or eight dates in.’ Whereas on Twitter, you could be dropping lore every five seconds.”

With the internet permeating so much of our everyday lives, the separation between online and offline relationships can blur.

Recently, when a friendly stranger asked how I met my boyfriend, I was prepared to offer my canned version of the story: We were close friends for seven years, and after our friends pestered us about it long enough, we finally got together.

My boyfriend's answer was a bit more blunt.

"We met on a meme page," he said.



The internet provides beautiful connections of all sorts, all the time.

With some surprise and amusement, I realized that his version of events was correct, too.

While we did start dating after many years of friendship, we first became friends because we were both moderators of a local Facebook meme group in 2017. We crossed paths in the irony-laden halls of ["weird Facebook,"](#) the same collection of esoteric meme groups where Zeke and Owen met.

"There's always a responsible distance that people should put between their presence online and themselves," Rudy said. "But I think the internet provides beautiful connections of all sorts, all the time."

It's a bit weirder than meeting on Hinge, but so far, it's working.

Topics: [Apps](#) [dating apps](#) [online dating](#) [Social](#) [trends](#)



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Tinder explores a redesign, dating ‘modes,’ and college-specific features to boost engagement

Ivan Mehta — 6:40 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

Tinder is still struggling to generate revenue from its users, as it reported a 7% dip in paying users while its parent company, Match Group, saw a 5% dip in Q2 2025 across all dating apps, including Tinder, Hinge, Match.com, and others.

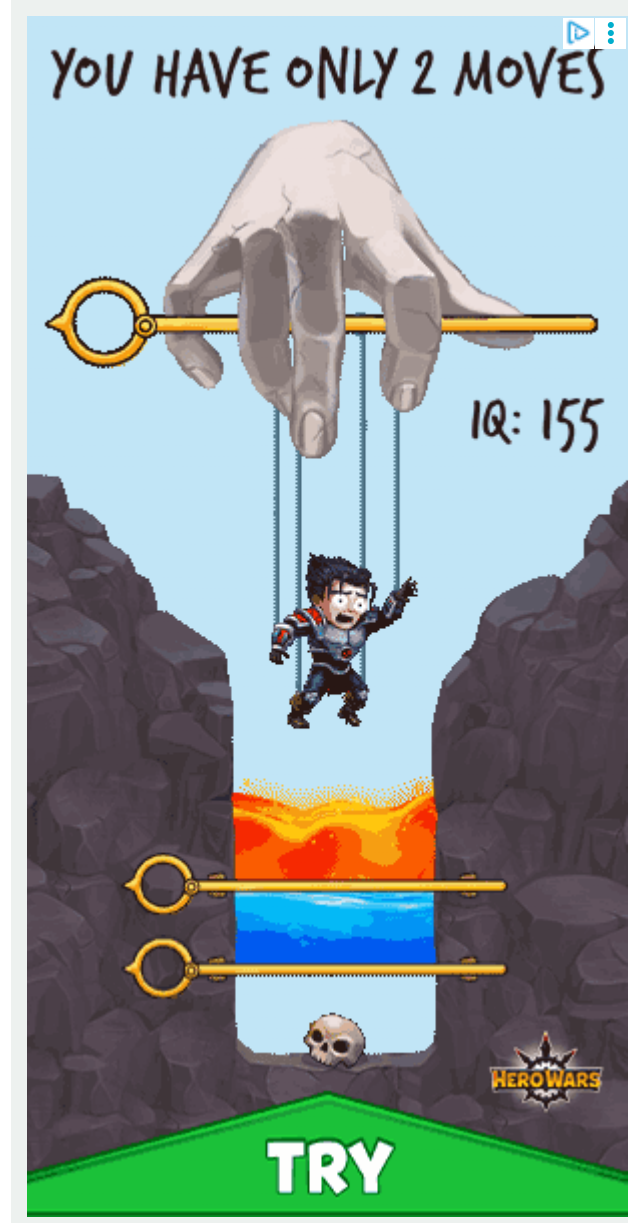
To boost engagement and push more people to pay for its product, the company has undertaken multiple new initiatives. During Match’s second-quarter earnings call, Match Group CEO Spencer Rascoff said that Tinder will debut a new feature called “modes,” which will allow users to switch between different dating goals to explore new connections in real time. This is similar to a previous option where Tinder allowed users to put their [relationship goals directly on their profiles](#).

Tinder will also explore a broader redesign and other new features, including those aimed at college students, to drive more usage among Gen Z.

Another new feature allows users to like specific parts of a profile, nudging people to start conversations based on those likes, similar to Match's dating app Hinge.

The changes arrive amid a mixed quarter for the dating app giant, which [reported](#) flat year-over-year revenue of \$864 million and earnings that declined from \$133.3 million year-over-year to \$122.5 million in Q2. However, the company provided a better-than-expected Q3 outlook with revenue reaching \$910-920 million, which boosted its stock post-earnings.

Match also announced it would invest \$50 million in product development, as the dating app maker aims to connect with younger Gen Z users and use AI to improve its products.

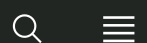


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Now, the company intends to roll out this feature to more geographies.

“The interactive matching experience we’ve been testing in New Zealand is specifically designed to appeal to this type of audience [users under 30]: Somebody who doesn’t just want to be judged based on their physical appearance. [The feature is for] somebody who instead is willing to put in a little bit of time, answer some questions, and then get a custom result back,” Rascoff said.

Plus, Rascoff noted that Tinder is thinking about launching more college-specific features, including allowing users to just search within their college or other selected colleges, to appeal to younger users.

The company also offered an update on Tinder’s [Double Date option](#), launched in June, that lets users pair up with a friend to match with another couple. The dating company said it saw positive results with 92% of users utilizing the feature being under 30.

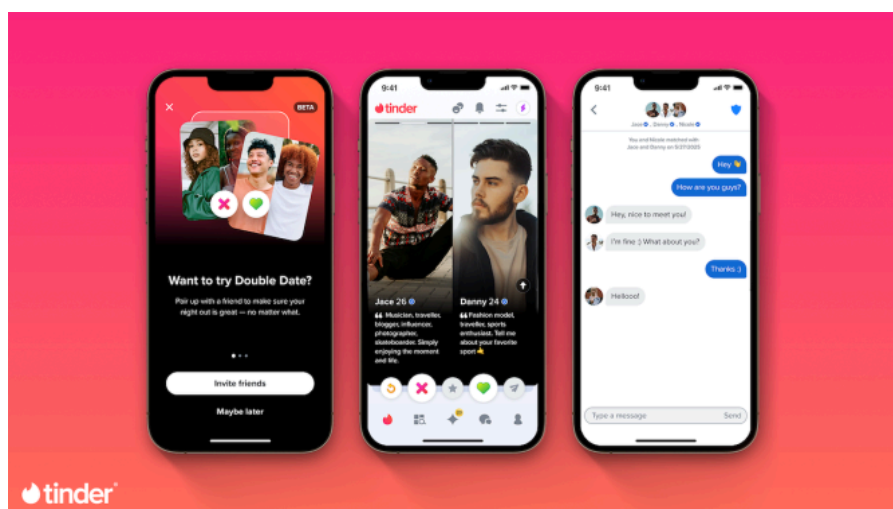


IMAGE CREDITS: TINDER

This was Rascoff’s first full quarter at the helm of Match Group, as the Zillow Group co-founder and Match board member was [appointed](#) CEO in February.

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Earlier this year, the company announced that Faye Iosotaluno would step down from the app's CEO position in July, with Rascoff taking on the role. The company also laid off 13% of its staff (around 325 people) in May, and [closed open roles](#).

Topics: [Apps](#) [dating apps](#) [Match Group](#) [Social](#)

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SECURITY



TeaOnHer, a rival Tea app for men, is leaking users' personal data and driver's licenses

Amanda Silberling, Zack Whittaker

12:40 PM PDT · August 6, 2025



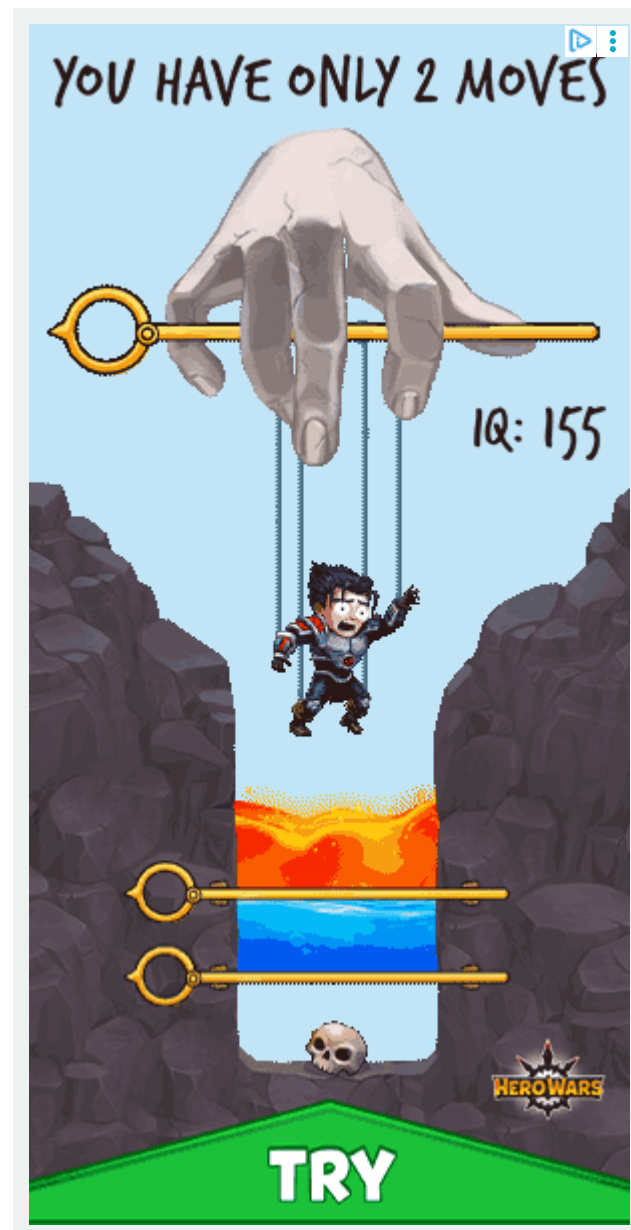
TeaOnHer, an app designed for men to share photos and information about women they have supposedly dated, has exposed users' personal information, including government IDs and selfies, TechCrunch can confirm.

The app, which launched on the Apple App Store earlier this week, is a response to another viral app Tea that allows women to post about the men they date. Tea is advertised as a women's safety app with more than 6 million users that is similar to "[Are we dating the same guy?](#)" Facebook networks. However, the app is controversial, since many of the claims that women post cannot be verified.

IMAGE CREDITS: TEAONHER (MODIFIED)

The backlash surrounding Tea escalated last week, after 404 Media reported 4chan users retaliated by [discovering a publicly exposed database](#) belonging to the app, which [revealed](#) over 72,000 images, including thousands of selfies and photo IDs submitted for account verification. A [subsequent hack](#) exposed more than 1 million private messages sent over the app, prompting the app to [disable](#) its messaging feature.

TeaOnHer, which is now ranked No. 2 among Lifestyle apps on iOS, appears to be a direct rebuttal to the Tea app, even copying the language from Tea's App Store description in its own listing.



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Data breach at French telecom giant Bouygues affects millions of customers

But like the app it sought to emulate, TeaOnHer contains security flaws of its own.

TechCrunch has found at least one security flaw that allows anyone access to data belonging to TeaOnHer app users, including their usernames and associated email addresses, as well as driver's licenses and selfies that users uploaded to TeaOnHer. Images of these driver's licenses are publicly accessible web addresses, allowing anyone with the links to access them using their web browser.

In one case, TechCrunch saw a list of posts shared on TeaOnHer appended with each user's email address, display name, and self-reported location.

TechCrunch is withholding some of the details of the bugs so as to not help malicious actors access anyone's data. The app's maker did not respond to emails from TechCrunch asking who we can report the flaws to. As such, TechCrunch is publishing this report with limited details of the issue, given the app's current popularity and the risk faced with using the app.

TeaOnHer was uploaded to the iOS App Store by a developer named Newville Media Corporation. According to LinkedIn, the founder and CEO of this company is Xavier Lampkin.

TechCrunch identified at least one TeaOnHer record associated with Lampkin's own data.

The security lapse will likely affect any user who signed up or shared identity documents with the app. The bug also exposes the number of users the TeaOnHer app has, which is about 53,000 users at the time of publication.

TechCrunch also identified a potential second security issue, in which an email address and

Zack Whittaker - 14 hours ago

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TeaOnHer, a rival Tea app for men, is leaking users' personal data and driver's licenses

Amanda Silberling,
Zack Whittaker

- 1 day ago

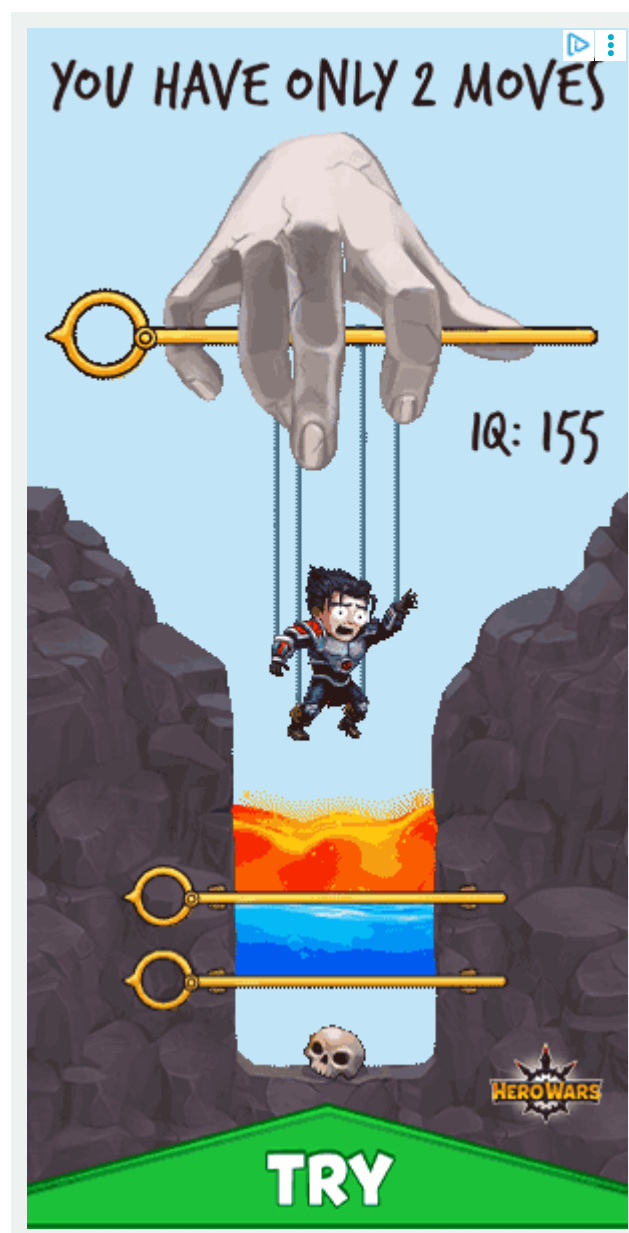
SECURITY



Citizen Lab director warns cyber industry about US authoritarian descent

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

- 2 days ago



plaintext password belonging to the app’s creator, Lampkin, was left exposed on the server. The credentials appear to grant access to the app’s “admin” panel. TechCrunch did not use the credentials, as doing so would be unlawful, but highlights the risks of inadvertently leaving admin credentials exposed to the web.

Along with its security flaws, the content portrayed within TeaOnHer is troubling in itself. While the app requests IDs and selfies from its users to verify their identities — a process that is not automatic — users can access a “guest” view of the app without signing in.

Immediately upon opening “guest” view, TechCrunch saw several images of the same naked woman, posted under different names in a form of spam. It is not clear if this woman consented to this photo being shared. Other posts share the photos and names of women, alongside comments calling them “easy,” or accusing them of spreading sexually transmitted infections.

Across all free apps, TeaOnHer is ranked No. 17, higher than apps like Instagram, Netflix, Uber, and Spotify. Tea is currently ranked No. 2.

Topics: [apple app store](#) [cybersecurity](#) [data protection](#)

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